

INTRODUCTION TO CHILDHOOD STUDIES



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Bridgewater State University

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Introduction to Childhood Studies

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1: Historical and Contemporary Definitions of Childhood

Learning Objectives

In this chapter, you will

1. Appraise the historical and contemporary definitions of childhood.
2. Brainstorm issues concerned with the well-being of children.

What is Childhood Studies?

James and James (2012) define Childhood Studies as *the interdisciplinary study of the early period of the human life-course that is legally recognized, socially, and scientifically defined as childhood, as distinct from adulthood* (p. 18).

Why study Childhood?

Would you agree that childhood experiences have a lifelong impact? I believe that childhood experiences build the foundation for learning and life. I studied child development as an undergraduate student. In my program, I learned how development occurs within the context of family, community, culture, and relationships as well the complex interaction among developmental domains of the child and the role of environmental factors. I was able to use my understanding as a preschool teacher. I was able to identify, interpret, and respond to a child's individual differences, needs, challenges, and capacities to support families in giving children a positive start in life. As you progress through this course, think about how your increased understanding of children will prepare you for possibility working with children and families.

How do you study childhood?

Understanding the concept of childhood is complex and must consider many influences and perspectives. Thus, an interdisciplinary approach is most beneficial. What is an interdisciplinary approach? First, we need to define a discipline which is a branch of knowledge; an area of study. An academic discipline or field of study is a branch of knowledge that is taught and researched as part of higher education. Figure 1.1 lists disciplines involved in the study of childhood.



Figure 1.1: Disciplines involved in the study of childhood.

What disciplines study children?

Different disciplines have developed unique ways of approaching the study of children, using different research methods driven by research questions. For some disciplines (such as sociology and cultural studies) childhood as a concept is specifically addressed looking at childhood as a social construction and a variable of social analysis. They would study children's relationships and cultures; and children as active social agents. A research method used by sociologists is ethnography. In contrast, other disciplines, such as psychology and education, the focus of research is on the child or children. I engage in interdisciplinary research to study childhood with a registered architect. To see our work you can read the brief article: [Seven Home Design Elements To Help Children Learn Language](#)

I compiled a chart to illustrate how disciplines can contribute to the understanding of childhood. Explore at the journals listed below, found from a [comprehensive list at Rutgers](#) You can use journals that you are familiar with from previous courses. You will have to go to your college or university library to access the full text articles.

Discipline	Focus	Example of contribution to Childhood Studies	Possible Journal to Investigate
Psychology	All aspects of children's development from birth to adolescence; focusing on the period between birth and 18 years old.	Theories of Piaget and Vygotsky explain how children move through developmental stages and some moving faster or slower than others.	<i>Developmental Psychology</i>
Law	Defines child as anyone between the ages of 0 and 18.	Are/should children under the age of 18 years exempt from criminal liability?	<i>Children's Legal Rights Journal</i>
Health/Biology	Biological or physical development of children (stages of growth).	How much physical activity do children need to maintain health and mobility?	<i>Children's Health Care</i>
Social Work	Mental health & quality of life Human rights are at the heart of social work.	Helps children and families more effectively cope with the stresses of life and to deal with systemic problems such as child abuse and homelessness.	<i>Child Abuse and Neglect Adoption Quarterly</i>
Sociology	Cultural view of child specific to time and place	A study about children's rights and educational policy in Europe: The implementation of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child.	<i>British Journal of Sociology of Education</i>
Education	Cognitive development of children or learning.	Could focus on topics such as: curriculum, child care programs, administration, staff development, family-school relationships, equity issues, multicultural education, facilities, and special needs.	<i>Childhood Education</i>
Anthropology	Sees children as social actors in their own right and seeks to document their perspectives on, and participation in, the social world. They study different kinds of childhood in different societies.	Should childhood be seen as a cultural universal?	<i>Children's Geographies</i>
History	Compares children's lives as they were in the past paralleled to how children may live their lives in the modern day.	Children in the past worked at a younger age than is acceptable now.	<i>Journal of the History of Childhood and Youth</i>
English/Communication	Looks at representation of children in media and literature.	Look at the history of children's literature. How has the Cinderella story changed over time?	<i>Red Feather Journal: An International Journal of Children in Popular Culture</i>

Discipline	Focus	Example of contribution to Childhood Studies	Possible Journal to Investigate
Philosophy	Concerned with understanding the nature of children.	Theories by Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1762) who believed that children should be kept away from the corruption of adults and left to develop in a manner which would keep them good. Philosophy contrasts this view with the philosopher John Locke (1690) who saw children as being neither good nor bad believing that children's behavior and personalities are molded by giving children strong discipline and education.	<i>Questions: Philosophy for Young People</i>
The Arts (visual, dance, music, & theater)	Focuses on the connection between arts-participation and human development	The Importance of Art in Child Development	<i>ArtsEdSearch</i>

An interdisciplinary approach is beneficial to understanding the lives of children and youth; because it enables researchers to gain information from different sources and compare the ways children are viewed, understood and taken care of in different parts of the world. An interdisciplinary approach also enables us to look at and compare children's lives in the modern day and in the past, and to look at the way in which children are diverse and how these diversities affect the speed they move through the different stages of childhood development at different rates. Nissani (1997) promotes interdisciplinary knowledge and research listing several benefits. Some the benefits include: Creativity is enhanced in an interdisciplinary study. Errors and assumptions are often detecting when working with people from outside our discipline. Many topics related to childhood intersect traditional disciplines. And, by using an interdisciplinary approach we may bridge communication gaps helping to mobilize resources in the cause of greater social justice.

To begin our interdisciplinary look at childhood, consider these questions and how you might examine childhood from a variety of perspectives.

- Did you have a *normal* childhood?
- What is a normal childhood?

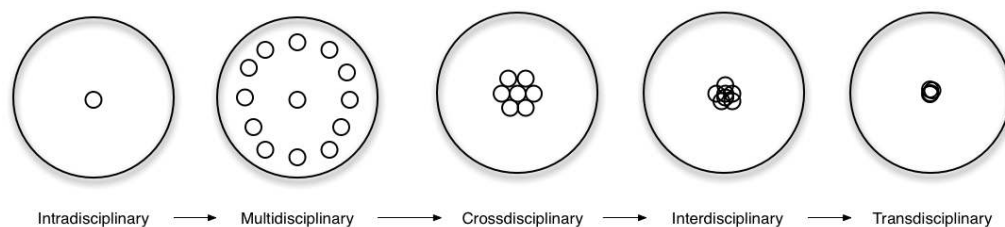


Figure 1.1: Copy and Paste Caption here. (<http://www.arj.no/2012/03/12/disciplinarity-2>)

Source of below: <https://blogs.lt.vt.edu/grad5104/mul...he-difference/>

ccording to Oxforddictionaries.com:

multidisciplinary is an adjective that describes, “combining or involving several academic disciplines or professional specializations in approach to a topic or problem.”

Interdisciplinary is an adjective that describes, “of or relating to more than one branch of knowledge.”

Transdisciplinary is also an adjective that describes, “relating to more than one branch of knowledge.”

So what exactly is the difference?

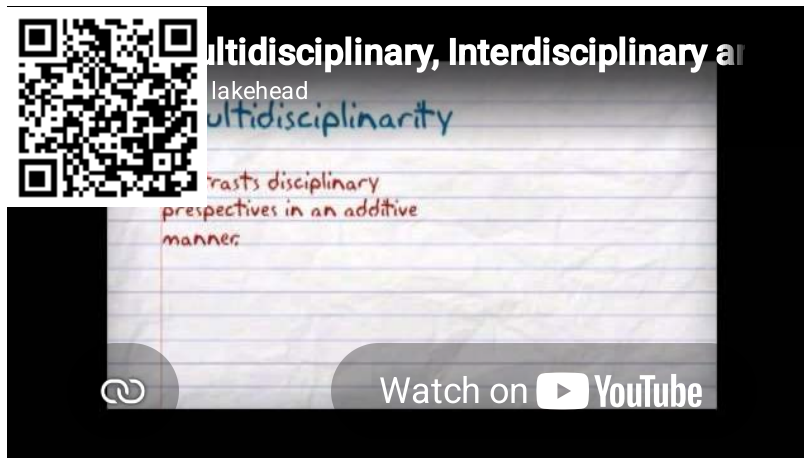
According to Lakehead University's "Essential Guide to Writing Research Papers," multidisciplinary contrasts disciplinary perspectives in an additive manner, meaning two or more disciplines each provide their viewpoint on a problem from their perspectives. Multidisciplinary involves little interaction across disciplines.

Interdisciplinarity combines two or more disciplines to a new level of integration suggesting component boundaries start to break down. Interdisciplinarity is no longer a simple addition of parts but the recognition that each discipline can affect the research output of the other.

Transdisciplinarity occurs when two or more discipline perspectives transcend each other to form a new holistic approach. The outcome will be completely different from what one would expect from the addition of the parts. Transdisciplinarity results in a type xenogenesis where output is created as a result of disciplines integrating to become something completely new.

Take a look at the video below and compare the practices to your own research. Do you engage in multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary, or transdisciplinary research? Could your output benefit from one or more of these practices? Are there barriers or obstacles within your discipline that prevent cross-departmental collaboration? Are there opportunities for collaboration in your research?

I conclude this entry with a quote from American architect, Buckminster Fuller, "in order to change an existing paradigm you do not struggle to try and change the problematic model. You create a new model and make the old one obsolete. That, in essence is the higher service to which we are all being called."



Video 1.1: A brief look at the differences between multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary.

To explore an interdisciplinary approach where the author uses her knowledge of social anthropology with the tools of history to study children. Read the 2013 article [Different Cultures, Different Childhoods](#). Montgomery gives a brief overview of how the historical context and culture influence what is considered typical for a child. **How might you describe an ideal childhood?**

Now, view the 75-minute video [Babies \(2010\) Bébé\(s\) \(original title\)](#). BSU students can view the video on Blackboard. The PG rated documentary focuses on four newborns, photographed in their natural habitat in distinctly different parts of the world. Hattie is in San Francisco, Mari's in Tokyo, Baryarjargal lives out in the Mongolian steppes, and Ponijao is born amid the simple straw huts of Namibia. You will follow the babies through their first year of life. As you watch the video, you may want to complete the reading reflection form available on Blackboard as a way to take notes and organize your thinking.

After reading this chapter and completing the activities you should be able to

1. Appraise the historical and contemporary definitions of childhood as seen the discussions either in class or online
2. Brainstorm issues concerned with the well-being of children to explore in two projects during the class.

Challenges

Challenge 1 Discussion Ideas

Think about:

- What is childhood?

- How would you define “child” and “childhood”?
- How do time and place influence your definition?
- How is childhood different from other stages of life, and what does it share in common with them?
- When does childhood begin and end?
- What are children capable of? What abilities and understandings are beyond the reach of children? How pliable are they?
- What are your assumptions about and perceptions of children?
- How would you complete these sentences?
 - Children should
 - Children should not

Now you are ready to type in Pages or in a Word document, a minimum of 3 paragraphs explaining your connections, extensions, and curiosities. Copy and paste your response in the Blackboard discussion about “child” and “childhood” or bring to class.

References

Balmès, T. (Director), & Chabat, A., Billot, A., & Rouxel, C. (Producers). (2010). *Babies* [Motion picture on DVD]. Universal Studios Home Entertainment.

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2: Studying Childhood through an Interdisciplinary Framework

Learning Objectives

- Develop an interdisciplinary framework from which to examine a specific research question.
- Identify 3 major challenges facing children today.
- Explain the role of disciplines in ethical, practical, and political responses to children's well-being.
- Describe how disciplines advocate for action for the benefit and well-being of children.

Terms to Consider

During your work this week, you will likely visit these concepts.

- **Children's Places:** Spaces children choose to occupy and make use of in their everyday lives and the ways in which they understand their environment.
- **Disappearance or loss of childhood:** The idea that the differences between children and adults are becoming less pronounced and that this is creating problems for children.
- **Internet and Social Media:** Children's engagement with electronic media of all kinds.
- **Sexualization:** The material cultural practices of treating young girls as if they were young women.
- **Spaces for Children:** Built environments that are suitable for use by children .

This week we will explore interdisciplinary frameworks used to examine your research questions for the group project. There are samples of past projects and poster available on Blackboard.

Your Poster Presentation Project will **clearly describe how you used insights from different disciplines to more fully understand the issue.**

What are some current topics that you could explore further as progress through the Childhood Studies Minor at Bridgewater State University? I included 4 possible areas to investigate and the list is endless as you will see in the resource I included.

Children's Places and Spaces

Since the 1970s, how children use environments and how physical environments influence child development have been important topics in environmental psychology and and behavior studies. This area of interdisciplinary studies brings together social scientists with urban planners and designers, architects, and landscape architects. Then cognitive psychologists became involved with the goal of understanding how to create environments that best support children. [Holloway and Valentine 2000](#) were influenced by the sociology of childhood, which argues that childhood and children's use of space are social constructions, and therefore it emphasizes changes in children's place experience depending on social contexts. [Dudek 2005](#) and [Day and Midbjer 2007](#) illustrate efforts by architects to apply principles of child development to design. **How does the environment shape development?**

Disappearance or loss of childhood

Are children different today than when you were growing up? Is childhood disappearing? Is the distinction between adulthood and childhood is narrowing? Over 20 years ago, in 1994, Neil Postman argued that childhood is 'disappearing at a dazzling speed'. He supported his position with the trend towards giving children the same rights as adults, the growing similarity of adult and children's clothing and even cases of children committing 'adult crimes' (murder, rape). He added that electronic media blur this separation and that children are now much more able to access the 'adult world'. As a result, childhood as we know it is disappearing. I would add that children have more pressure for academic achievement and that helicopter parents add to their stress.

Not everyone agrees with Postman. Some people believe that childhood is just more complex, and that children are more protected with labor and welfare laws. **Do you think is childhood disappearing?**

The disciplines of English, Communications, Arts, History, and Psychology could be helpful in studying this area more thoroughly.

Internet and Social Media

Does using the Internet affect children's development? How often do children use the internet? Do children become socially isolated or connected when they use the Internet? Do they become depressed or elated? Does school performance suffer or improve?

There seems to be both positive and negative effects of electronic media usage on children. Some of the positive effects of social media usage are socializing and sharing common interests; a space where children and youth can be creative, interact, and learn (Chau, 2010); an alternative way to get students interested in learning with a new and previously unconventional medium (Rosen, 2011); and assisting with “homework and group projects” (Clark-Pearson, O’Keeffe, 2011). Social networking can help shy adolescents. (Rosen, 2011). Additionally, adolescents who use Facebook have been shown to demonstrate more “virtual empathy” (Rosen, 2011).

Some of the negative effect, especially for adolescents, include a decrease in the level of contentment, an increase of getting into trouble or being depressed (Rideout, 2010; and teens who use Facebook tend to be more narcissistic, antisocial, and aggressive (Rosen, 2011).

Cyberbullying has also been the cause of many suicides in young people (Kowalski, 2009). Many young online users are lured by online sexual predators (Ybarra, 2007). Another problem is that many adolescents are unaware of the privacy policies on the social media websites they use (Cox, 2007).

Many children and youth are influenced by the powerful advertising they see on social media sites, and it strongly influences their buying habits. Studies have shown that adolescents and even college students who are on Facebook too much have lower grades (Rosen, 2011). So is social media usage good or bad? The disciplines of English, Communications, Arts, History, Criminal Justice, Sociology, Social Work, and Psychology could be helpful in studying this area more thoroughly.

Sexualization

A 2007 report from the American Psychological Association (APA) found evidence that the increase of sexualized images of girls and young women in advertising, merchandising, and media is harmful to girls’ self-image and healthy development.

Sexualization was defined as when a person’s value comes only from their sexual appeal, to the exclusion of other characteristics, and when a person is sexually objectified, such as when they are made into a *thing* for another’s sexual use.

The report includes examples of the sexualization of girls in all forms of media including visual media and other forms of media such as music lyrics abound. The influence and attitudes of parents, siblings, and friends can also add to the pressures of sexualization.

Research showed that the sexualization of girls negatively affects girls and young women across a variety of health domains:

Cognitive and Emotional Consequences: Sexualization and objectification undermine a person’s confidence in and comfort with her own body, leading to emotional and self-image problems, such as shame and anxiety.

Mental and Physical Health: Research links sexualization with three of the most common mental health problems diagnosed in girls and women—eating disorders, low self-esteem, and depression or depressed mood.

Sexual Development: Research suggests that the sexualization of girls has negative consequences on girls’ ability to develop a healthy sexual self-image.

According to [the task force report](#), parents can play a major role in contributing to the sexualization of their daughters or can play a protective and educative role. The disciplines of Psychology, Sociology, Health, Medicine, and Biology could be helpful in studying this area more thoroughly.

Current Topics Researched in Childhood Studies

Did you know that Childhood Studies is one of the most active fields in academia today? In the past, children might have been seen as passive, dependent or incomplete, they are now seen by researchers as equal participants in society, differently competent to adults, but of interest for what they are now, not only what they will become. Children’s rights, and the changing relationship between families and children, are central to the field. [Oxford Bibliographies in Childhood Studies](#) is a helpful place to discover more about current research in Childhood Studies.

Careers and Childhood Studies

A wide range of career options are open to students who complete the Childhood Studies degree program. Sample career paths might be:

- Law as a child advocate
- Children's publishing (print & web)
- Social work
- School or community counseling
- Children's museums
- Children's theater
- Early Education and Care
- Recreation
- Advocacy and public service
- Health and wellness

Additional career options are outlined in the attached document available at:

<https://whatcanidowiththismajor.com/major/wp-content/uploads/2017/05/child-familystudies.pdf>

To prepare for the wide variety of possible career options, we encourage

Childhood Studies students to pursue majors and minors related to their career goals. This is a list of minors available at Bridgewater State:

- Accounting and Finance Minor
- African American Studies Minor
- African Studies Minor
- American Studies Minor
- Anthropology Minor
- Art History Minor
- Asian Studies Minor
- Canadian Studies Minor
- Civic Education and Community Leadership Minor
- Classical Studies Minor
- Coaching Minor
- Communication Disorders Minor
- Communication Studies Minor
- Computer Science Minor
- Criminal Justice Minor
- Dance Minor
- Economics Minor
- English Literature and Literary Studies Minor
- Exercise Physiology Minor
- Film Studies Minor
- GLBT Studies Minor
- Global Religious Studies Minor
- Graphic Design Minor
- Health Promotion Minor
- Health Resources Management Minor
- History Minor
- Irish Studies Minor
- Latin American and Caribbean Studies Minor
- Management Minor
- Middle East Studies Minor
- Music Minor
- Musical Theatre Performance Minor

- Nutrition Minor
- Philosophy Minor
- Philosophy, Politics and Economics Minor
- Political Science Minor
- Portuguese Minor
- Psychology Minor
- Public Relations Minor
- Reading Minor
- Recreation Minor
- Social Studies Minor
- Social Welfare Minor
- Sociology Minor
- Spanish Minor
- Special Education, Inclusive Practices in Special Education Minor
- Statistics Minor
- Studio Art Minor
- Sustainability Innovation and Outreach Minor
- Theatre Arts Minor
- U.S. Ethnic and Indigenous Studies Minor
- Urban Affairs Minor
- Women's and Gender Studies Minor
- Writing and Writing Studies Minor
- Teaching English to Speakers of Other Languages (TESOL) Undergraduate Certificate

Think about how you see yourself working with children and families.

After participating in discussion you should be able to:

- Develop an interdisciplinary framework from which to examine a specific research question.
- Identify 3 major challenges facing children today
- Explain the role of disciplines in ethical, practical, and political responses to children's well-being.
- Describe how disciplines advocate for action for the benefit and well-being of children.

Exercise 2.1: Creating an electronic portfolio

To document your learning in the minor, which includes this course, you can begin to create an electronic portfolio. The portfolio will be used for those of you in the Childhood Studies minor during the Capstone course: CHST 400. All students benefit from creating an electronic portfolio according to the [Association of American Colleges & Universities](#). Your reflection on work submitted in e-portfolios can:

- Build your personal and academic identity as you reflect on your capabilities and progress
- Facilitate the integration of learning as you connect learning across courses and time
- Develop self-assessment abilities by judging the quality of the work you produce
- Assist with planning your academic path as you come to understand what you know and can do as well as goals for future learning.
- Be helpful when applying to graduate school or applying for job opportunities

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Chau, C. (2010). You Tube as a participatory culture. Wiley Periodicals, Inc., 128, 65-74.

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3: Rights and Responsibilities during Childhood

Learning Objectives

- Explain how various disciplines understand the factors that impede or empower children's capacity and potential.
- Describe how free will and agency of children determined.
- Examine if adults consider children's own perspectives.
- Analyze adults beliefs about childhood enable or hinder children's agency, will, logic, or reason.

In our definitions of children from the discussion of Chapter 1, how did we consider the child's voice? How do children demonstrate free will or agency? What cultural structures support or hinder childhood? This week we will explore:

- How do various disciplines understand the factors that impede or empower children's capacity and potential?
- How are the free will and agency of children determined? Are children's own perspectives considered?
- Do notions about childhood enable or hinder children's agency?

Terms and Definitions

Important concepts to look for in this chapter:

- **Agency:** The capacity of individuals to act independently and to make their own free choices.
- **Best Interest:** The standard for decision making related to children and their UNCRC rights.
- Child-focused Research
- **Children's voices:** The process if allowing children to articulate their views on matters that concern them.
- **Family:** A group of people of different generations who have been or are related by marriage and share kinship ties. A child friendly definition is people that live together who love and care for each other.
- **Global Childhood:** Children in different parts of the world share similar experiences of childhood.
- **Nature & Nurture:** The dance of the impact of nature (genetic predisposition) and nurture (social, environmental and child-rearing influences).
- **Needs:** Something that is necessary
- **Neglect:** Failure by a caretaker, either deliberately or through negligence or inability to take those actions necessary to provide a child with minimally adequate food, clothing, shelter, medical care, supervision, emotional stability and growth, or other essential care; provided, however, that such inability is not due solely to inadequate economic resources or solely to the existence of a handicapping condition. This definition is not dependent upon location (i.e., neglect can occur while the child is in an out-of-home setting).
- **Protection:** Of children by the government from deliberate or inadvertent harm, most usually in the context of family relations. In MA, the [Department of Children and Families](#) protects children from abuse and neglect and, in partnership with families and communities, ensure children are able to grow and thrive in a safe and nurturing environment.
- **Resilience:** process of adapting well in the face of adversity, trauma, tragedy, threats, or even significant sources of stress — such as family and relationship problems, serious health problems, or workplace and financial stressors. It means “bouncing back” from difficult experiences. ([American Psychological Association](#))
- **Rights** as defined by the **UNCRC:** The [United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child](#) is a comprehensive, internationally binding agreement on the rights of children, which was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 1989. It is the most widely ratified human rights treaty in history: all countries have ratified it with the exception of the United States of America and Somalia.
- **Vulnerability:** At risk from harm and in need of protection.

Historically

As you read Mayhew's *The Watercress Girl* examine how the historical views of children provide a contrast to modern views. The introductory portion of Mayhew's article addresses his expectations of childhood and the assumptions he makes of the readers expectations. He describes the girl and how he hopes to communicate with her about childhood. The shock factor of the article and his revelations on the conditions of the poor relies upon this introduction. In order to help promote social change, Mayhew explains what people commonly believe childhood to be and through the use of the Watercress girl's voice he slowly addresses assumptions.

How does reading this article influence your thinking about children?

Legal definitions of childhood emerged and changed over time. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child, or UNCRC is the most complete statement of children's rights ever produced and is the most widely-ratified international human rights treaty in history. We will use the document frequently for the remainder of the course. You can learn more about the document at [the link provided in Terms and Definitions](#). **Please read and download the 2 pdf files** (full text and a child-friendly summary available on Blackboard) which are the 54 articles that cover all aspects of a child's life and set out the civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights that all children everywhere are entitled to. The document explains how adults and governments should work together to make sure all children enjoy all of their rights. The Convention changed the way children are viewed and treated – as human beings with a distinct set of rights instead of as passive objects of care and charity. **What are your thoughts about the UNCRC? What is necessary for all children?**

Agency and Structure

What does it mean to live in a globalized world? Think about the movement of people, beginning with Columbus arriving in the new world. Consider how contemporary forces of global interconnectedness and how communications make this connectedness possible. How might children be impacted by all the movements? Does the movement of people impact health care, ideas, language, and/or food? For example, where did the ingredients from your breakfast come from? To learn more, see an online magazine that illustrates global connections: [How are we connected?](#)

In social science, **agency is the capacity of individuals to act independently and to make their own free choices**. By contrast, structure is factors of influence, such as social class, religion, gender, ethnicity, and customs, that determine or limit an individual and their decisions. **If you have agency what does that mean?**

Children haven't been given much opportunities to be agents and agency is **culturally determined**. We can't always act on our free will. In studying children, researchers primarily focus on structure or environmental influences. There is a relationship between structure and agency which social scientist are interested in studying.

As you watch the film clip [3C's Children and Community for Change](#): **Are you seeing structure or agency? Are children a minority with limited power and privilege? Should children have a voice? How do you hear children's voices?**

Summary

This week you explored how various disciplines understand the factors that impede or empower children's capacity and potential. You examined how free will and agency of children are determined. It is helpful to look at childhood from a variety of angles. A student shared: *The experience of eating with a family from India really made me think of how a child must feel at school, when all her peers are looking at her with a puzzled look as they all eat with forks during lunch and she doesn't. The whole experience really allowed me to become more accepting and respectful of other's cultures and traditions!*

Look at my photos of a waterfall and how it looks different depending on where and how I viewed it. The same is true of studying childhood with an interdisciplinary focus.

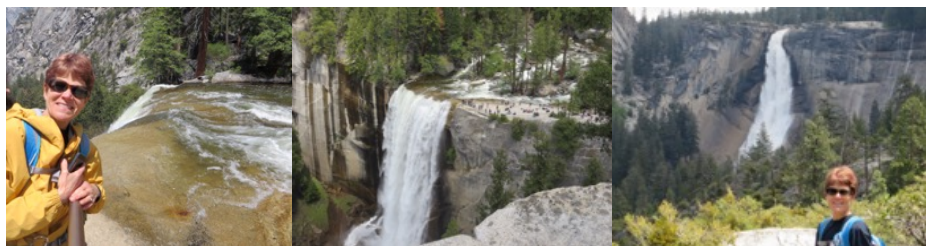


Figure 3.1: Waterfalls views

As you viewed [3C's Children and Community for Change](#): did you feel like this former student, *We often don't listen to children as much as we should and they do have a lot to say*? **Did you see structure or agency? Are children a minority with limited power and privilege? Should children have a voice? How do you hear children's voices in your daily life?**

In the next 2 chapters we will look more closely at influences on childhood.

After reading this chapter and completing the activities you should be able to

- Explain how various disciplines understand the factors that impede or empower children's capacity and potential as seen in discussions and in the project proposal.
- Describe how free will and agency of children determined as seen in the discussion.

- Examine if adults consider children’s own perspectives as seen in the discussion.
- Analyze adults beliefs about childhood enable or hinder children’s agency, will, logic, or reason as seen in the discussion.

Challenges

Exercise 3.1: Reflection and Discussion

Our reading, activities, and discussion for the week focus on answering:

- How do various disciplines understand the factors that impede or empower children’s capacity and potential?
- How are the free will and agency of children determined? Are children’s own perspectives considered?
- Do notions about childhood enable or hinder children’s agency, will, logic, or reason?

As you read and write this week contemplate these ideas:

Agency	Nature & Nurture	Resilience
Best Interest	Needs	Rights as defined by the UNCRC
Children’s voices	Neglect	Vulnerability
Global	Protection	

One structural support for childhood is the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child Convention. What are your thoughts about the UNCRC? What is necessary for all children? As you view 3C’s Children and Community for Change: Did you see structure or agency? Are children a minority with limited power and privilege? Should children have a voice? How do you hear children’s voices in your daily life?

Now you are ready to type in Pages or in a Word document, a minimum of 3 paragraphs explaining your connections, extensions, and curiosities. Copy and paste your response in the Blackboard discussion or bring to class.

Exercise 3.2: Assumptions Inventory

This week you may start to examine your assumptions about childhood. At the beginning of next week you will post your assumptions inventory assignment. I challenge you to begin to brainstorm ideas about your assumptions. The Assumption Inventory is submitted as an spoken rather than written assignment. In a 3 to 5-minute oral presentation, identify an assumption you have about children or childhood, and explain how and why it exists. Why do you believe it? Have the readings, videos, and/or discussions changed your thinking? Why or Why not? Ideally create a PowerPoint and embed your videotape. If this not possible, record a video or upload a link to You Tube to post to a blackboard discussion for others to see and comment on.

Examples

A student noticed that many 4 to 8-year-old children have iPads and discussed how easily children use them. They assumed young children are naturally good at using technology such as iPhones and iPads. They discussed a study that compared preschool children and college student use of novel technology. Using statistics and examples the student made a logical and persuasive analysis of how young children problem solved but as the readings discussed problem solving is because of flexibility and not necessarily natural ability. Her assumption was proved wrong.

Other assumptions include:

- Children between the ages of 2 and 7 years benefit from watching PBS, Nick Jr., Sesame Street and other “educational” programming on TV.
- Adults find children inferior.
- Teachers should help children grow and develop by working directly **only** with them because of limited contact with families. Family involvement in not useful.

See Blackboard for a power point example of what to submit and how you will be assessed.

Grading Rubric

Criteria	Emerging Understanding	Acceptable	Target	Points
Identified Assumption explaining the source and why you may have developed the assumption.	Your assumption was unclear. Not enough information to determine the source or the reason why you have this assumption.	Your assumption was explained enough to understand the origin and reason. Some questions may exist about the reason or the source.	Your assumption was clear and thoroughly explained. The source was evident and the reason why the assumption developed was persuasive.	15
Identified concrete piece(s) of information from the readings, discussions, or films viewed	You did not identify a source.	You identified a source.	You identified a specific source clearly enough others could locate it.	15
Analyzed how the information challenged or affirmed their assumption	You did not include an analysis. The analysis was unclear and/or didn't seem logical.	You presented an analysis.	The analysis was thorough, logical, and easy to understand.	15
Non-verbal communication	Little eye contact and your posture was closed and not confident.	You maintained eye contact most of the time and your posture was open.	Positive, open, and confident posture and maintained eye contact with audience.	10
Verbal communication skills	Inappropriate or ineffective word choice.	Some of the words you chose could be replaced, but for the most part, your speech was clear and appropriate.	Your word choice was effective and appropriate for our class. You avoided "ums," "ers," and "likes."	15
Use of Time	Your message was too short or too long.	Your speech was between 2 – 3 minutes OR 5 to 6 minutes.	Maintained time frame of 3 to 5 minutes.	10
Comments to Peers	Did not comment to peers Commented to 1 peer	Commented on 2 peer video	Commented on 3 peer videos	20

Criteria	Emerging Understanding	Acceptable	Target	Points
Total				100

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4: Influences of Family, Society, and Culture on Childhood

Learning Objectives

This week you will:

- Describe and analyze the influences of family, society, and culture influence the lives of children.

Introduction

How are childhoods influenced by nature and nurture? This week we will consider how family society and culture influence the lives of children. You will explore how the natural sciences (biology) and social sciences (anthropology, psychology, social work, and sociology) study these influences on children. We will use an interdisciplinary approach to learn more about the topic of sexuality. I like to use [Urie Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory](#) to illustrate how the influences of nurture impact childhood. Watch [Urie Bronfenbrenner Ecological Theory explained on You Tube](#) on Blackboard to learn more about this model. **How might Urie Bronfenbrenner's Ecological theory help you study your research question or childhood in general?**

Terms and Definitions

Important concepts to look for in this chapter:

- **Socialization:** the process where children learn to meet the expectations of and how to fit into a society.
- **Play is:**
 - self-chosen and self-directed
 - an activity in which means are more valued than end
 - structure, or rules determined by the players
 - imaginative, non-literal, mentally removed in some way from “real” or “serious” life
 - involves an active, alert, but non-stressed frame of mind. (Gray, 2008)
- **Competence:** The ability, capacity, or qualification to perform a task, fulfill a function, or meet the requirements of a role to an acceptable standard.
- **Cultural Relativism:** a person's beliefs and activities should be understood based on that person's own culture.
- **Developmentalism:** The behavior of children is shaped by physical, psychological, and emotional development. Maturity is determined by age and stage of development.
- **Diversity:** There are many different types of childhood.
- **Ethnicity:** The culture of people in a given geographic region, including their language, heritage, religion and customs. To be a member of an ethnic group is to conform to some or all of those practices. Race is associated with biology, whereas ethnicity is associated with culture.
- **Familialization:** the caring of children in individual households and homes by family members rather than in state institutions.
- **Gender:** The condition of being male, female, or neuter. In a human context, the distinction between gender and SEX reflects the usage of these terms: Sex usually refers to the biological aspects of maleness or femaleness, whereas gender implies the psychological, behavioral, social, and cultural aspects of being male or female (i.e., masculinity or femininity.) [American Psychological Association, 2015]
- **Friendship:** Children's affective social relations with their peers and others.

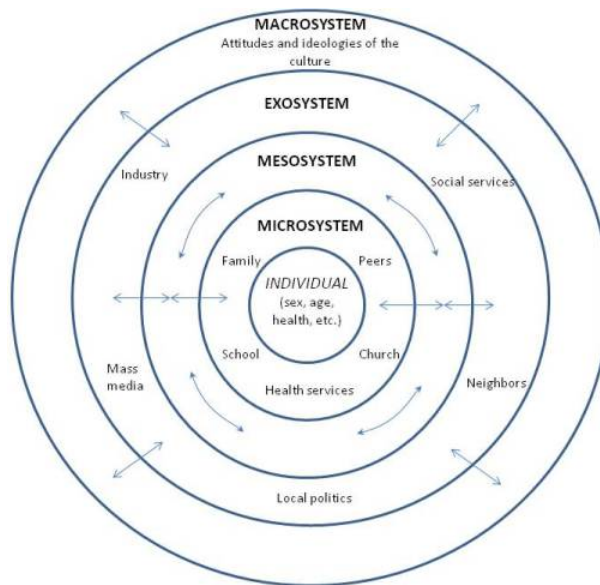
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Ecological Systems Theory – used often in Social Work

Urie Bronfenbrenner (1917-2005) developed the ecological systems theory to explain how everything in a child and the child's environment affects how a child grows and develops. The theory is illustrated in the figure below. This chapter will concentrate on the the Micro and Mesosystem levels. I find this model helpful in understanding the influences of nurture on childhood.



The **microsystem** is the small, immediate environment the child lives in. How these groups or organizations interact with the child will have an effect on how the child grows; the more encouraging and nurturing these relationships and places are, the better the child will be able to grow. Furthermore, how a child acts or reacts to these people in the microsystem will affect how they treat her in return. Each child's special genetic and biologically influenced personality traits, what is known as temperament, end up affecting how others treat them.

The **mesosystem**, describes how the different parts of a child's microsystem work together for the sake of the child. For example, if a child's caregivers take an active role in a child's school, such as going to parent-teacher conferences and watching their child's soccer games, this will help ensure the child's overall growth.

The **exosystem** includes the other people and places that the child herself may not interact with often herself but that still have a large effect on her, such as families workplaces, extended family members, the neighborhood,.

The **macrosystem**, which is the largest and most remote set of people and things to a child but which still has a great influence over the child. The macrosystem includes things such as the relative freedoms permitted by the national government, cultural values, the economy, wars, etc.

Chronosystem developmental processes vary according to the specific historical events that are occurring as the developing individuals are at one age or another. Moreover, cultures also are continually undergoing change.

As you read and explore the topics in the chapter, think about how the influences impact children.

Nature and Nurture Shape Childhood

Now, let's use the concept of sexuality to see how nature and nurture are interconnected.

Nature and nurture, biology and culture, work together to shape human lives. Nature and nurture are intertwined, processes.

- Do you assume biology (nature) is destiny that may be minimally modified by culture (nurture, or environment) throughout childhood?
- Do you assume environment (nurture) is a more important factor in shaping individual psychology than biology (nature)?
- Specifically, **what is the relationship between biology and culture with respect to sexuality?**

The biological features of sex and sexuality are determined by chromosomes and hormones such as testosterone, estrogen, and progesterone. Biologically, there are more than 2 sexes – chromosomes which can be XX, XY, XXX, XXY, XO, XYY. XX is female and XY is male; usually if the Y exists the person is generally seen as male. O produces ambiguous sexual features. Hormones and sex are apparent at seven weeks in utero.

The difference between sex and gender is: **sex** is male or female and is **biological**. **Gender** is meaning given to biological sex by **culture**. We develop a gender identity which is how an individual identifies as masculine or feminine. Gender is a spectrum. We learn gender roles during childhood, such as, appropriate behaviors and work or division of labor

- Can a male can be a female?
- Is it only one or the other?
- Are gender and sexuality fluid over a lifespan?
- Can they change? Is sex a spectrum like gender?
- Did you know the Navajo have four genders?
 - women
 - men
 - nadleehi (born male functions in women roles)
 - Dilbaa (born female functions in male role)

I **challenge** you to reflect on gender and sexual diversity. Imagine you have a child who is born with an intersex anatomy [XXX, XXY, XO, XYY] You read up on diagnostic testing and the recommendations of the [Intersex Society of North America](#), that suggest you give your child a binary gender assignment (girl or boy). **Do you follow the advice of the ISNA? Why/why not?** If not, what do you name your child? How do you dress your child?

As your child acquires language, **what pronouns do you use for your child? Would you use he, she, ze, or they?** You inform yourself and read about current possibilities at the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender Resource Center's article on [Gender Pronouns](#)

What is 'competency'?

Families should help children mature and become competent. The concept of competency is related to the concept of agency discussed in Chapter 2. Listening to children and respecting their opinions can contribute to their personal development. A supportive environment can lead to children to making better decisions, prepare them to participate in society and strengthen their accountability. Children's competency or abilities may be recognized, ignored, encouraged or inhibited. The supporting adults' willingness to respect children's decisions will determine whether the children's choices are honored Figure 1, described by Alderson (1992) and illustrated by Orr (1999), illustrate the internal and external variants that may influence a child's competency. (van Rooyen, Water, Rasmussen, & Diesfeld, 2015)

When we consider competence, we should also think about cultural relativism, **are there universal standards we can apply to childhood? Is the UNCRC a set of universal standards?** Implementation of the UNCRC can be difficult when violations of the rights of children are justified on the basis of cultural practice. Think about the practice of female circumcision.

In 1996, a 17-year-old girl named Fauziya Kassindja arrived at Newark International Airport and asked for asylum. She had fled her native country of Togo, a small west African nation, to escape what people there call excision.

Excision is a permanently disfiguring procedure that is sometimes called "female circumcision," although it bears little resemblance to the Jewish ritual. More commonly, at least in Western newspapers, it is referred to as "genital mutilation." According to the World Health Organization, the practice is widespread in 26 African nations, and two million girls each year are "excised." In some instances, excision is part of an elaborate tribal ritual, performed in small traditional villages, and girls look forward to it because it signals their acceptance into the adult world. In other instances, the practice is carried out by families living in cities on young women who desperately resist. For more information read the World Health Organization Fact sheet (2017) *Female genital mutilation*

Cultural relativism would accept the practice. **Does the UNCRC allow the practice?**

[Role of families](#)

As discussed during Week 1, we see the world through our cultural lens, we are cultural conditioned. Conditioning happens at different levels

- Global
- Societal [Macrosystem in Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory]
- Institutional [Exosystem in Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory]
- Group [Microsystem in Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory]
- Individual [The center of Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory]

The group level or microsystem in Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory includes families. One of the major influences on childhood is families. The family is the principal institution responsible for childbearing and childrearing so society assumes a

more passive role in facing the commitments and costs connected to childhood. The UNCRC gives all children the right to a family. The right to a family allows children to be connected to their history, and it offers a protective perimeter against violation of their rights. Children separated from their families can become victims of violence, exploitation, trafficking, discrimination and all other types of abuse. However, sometimes the family which should be protecting the child is in fact inflicting the abuse.

Families are the first to have the power to act on behalf of the child and ensure their rights are respected. Hopefully, their objectives are to protect the child and to secure the child an education, development, security, health and morality. To achieve these objectives, a family should provide supervision by controlling the child's comings and goings, relationships, and communications. For example, they may forbid the child from maintaining relationships with certain persons that they believe are not in his or her best interest. Families make educational decisions including religious and sex education and decide on the health care to give their child. Families are responsible for the needs of the child, such as food, clothing, shelter, educational costs, vacations (if possible), and health coverage. **What happens to children when families find it difficult to provide basic needs?** Families often struggle with finding time, money and resources to effectively parent. In the US, families may have difficulty earning a living wage, finding social supports, securing affordable housing, high-quality child care and paid family leave. It can be difficult to provide a nurturing environment all children need and may result in neglectful or abusive environment.

Did you know that in 2016 the relative poverty rate for children 0-5 in the U.S. was more than 25%; for ages 0-18 years the rate was about 22%. In other words about 1 out of 4 young children in the United States live in poverty. What changes in the US might lower the child poverty rate? **How can we create environments that enrich the lives of all young children and their families, allowing them the opportunity to realize their full human potential?**

A former student shared: *So I definitely think that the Department of Children and Families (DCF) needs to be more pro-active in checking in on families, especially families living under the poverty line, to ensure they are receiving assistance if needed and that the child is living in a stable home where he/she is healthy and can thrive.* I agree with the student that all children deserve a safe and healthy environment and our society should support them. I wonder why income often is the only resource considered when giving families assistance. To help you think about interacting with diverse families, please read the following scenario:

You are a teacher in the 4-year-old room at Kids Place child care center. Daequan and Mathew are two children in your class. Both were born at 30 weeks' gestation and had hospital stays of about 6 weeks. Both are in generally good health and are monitored for respiratory illnesses. For the most part, the boys are reaching their developmental milestones, with slight delays in language/emotional development.

At the present time, Daequan and his mother, Shania, are living in a homeless shelter. Their home burned down 2 weeks ago and they had nowhere else to go. Matthew is part of an intact family. Ralph and Sue are his parents, and he has an older brother, Nick. The family lives in an affluent community a mile from Kids Place.

- **Which child would appear to be experiencing a greater number of risk factors that can affect his development?**
- **With which family would it appear to be easier to develop a partnership? Why?**

Then you learn:

Daequan and his mother have a number of extended family members available for support and will be moving into an apartment within a month's time. Shania has contacted a number of local agencies for assistance to rebuild her and her son's lives.

Matthew's father travels 3 weeks out of the month. Sue is on medication for depression and has recently started drinking around the boys during the evenings and weekends. She turns down offers of help from her friends and family and tells them everything is fine with her marriage and her ability to raise her sons.

What questions might you or others ask to find out "the whole story"? Ruby Payne (2009) describes the nine resources by which one negotiates their environment. Poverty is when you need too many of these resources, not just financial.

1. Financial
2. Language (ability to speak formally)
3. Emotional
4. Mental
5. Spiritual
6. Physical
7. Support systems
8. Relationships/role models

9. Knowledge of middle class rules

How do you and other discover what resources are available to children and families? How do you build on a families strengths. Everything that improves the economic security, safety and peace of mind of families improves parenting—and increases children’s chances for growing into healthy, compassionate and responsible adults. These include living wages and reliable hours, secure housing, high-quality childcare, paid family leave, safe neighborhoods, flex time, desegregation and social inclusion. **Which disciplinary perspectives might help you understand family influences on childhood?**

Friendships

Besides family and other adults in the culture, peers can be an influence on childhood. Recent research shows the importance of friendship, and its impact on mental and physical health. Preschool friendships are helpful in developing social and emotional skills, increasing a sense of belonging and decreasing stress. (Yu, Ostrosky, & Fowler, 2011). People who feel lonely or socially isolated tend to be more depressed, have more health issues and may have a shorter lifespan. (Lewis, 2016). Having a support system can help us handle hardships.

Selman and colleagues identified five successive stages in how children view friendships. The chart below illustrates the theory. **Why might it be helpful to understand the stages of friendship? How would it inform your possible work with children and families?**

Stage 0 3 -7 year olds	Stage 1 Social Informational 4 – 9 year olds	Stage 2 Self-Reflective 6 -12 year olds	Stage 3 Third Party 11 – 15 year olds	Stage 4 Societal 12 – adulthood
Momentary Playmates	One-way Assistance	Fair Weather Cooperation	Intimate Mutually Shared Relationships	Mature Friendship
Based on proximity	Friends are important because they perform specific activities for me	Interpersonal relationships are reciprocal	Awareness of continuity of relationship and affective bonding	Friendship can grow and transform.
Play mate	A friend is known better than other persons	There is coordination of play and adjustments by self and others.	Conflicts do not mean the friendship ends	There is independence and dependence.
Issues such as jealousy or in the intrusion of a 3rd party into the play are seen as fights over toys or space rather than involving personal feelings or interpersonal affection.	There is knowledge of the other’s likes and dislikes. Reciprocity of actions	Give and take of thoughts and feelings.	Overemphasis on the 2-person clique and possessiveness	Draw strength from each other
“I Want It My Way”	What’s In It For Me?”	“By the Rules”	“Caring and Sharing”	“Friends Through Thick and Thin”

Play

Play in one way in which families and peers interact with the child. Play is essential to the cognitive, physical, social, and emotional well-being of children and youth and is one of the rights in the UNCRC. Article 31 of the UNCRC states:

1. Parties recognize the right of the child to rest and leisure, to engage in **play** and recreational activities appropriate to the age of the child and to participate freely in cultural life and the arts.
2. Parties shall respect and promote the right of the child to participate fully in cultural and artistic life and shall encourage the provision of appropriate and equal opportunities for cultural, artistic, recreational and leisure activity.

It is through play that children engage and interact in the world around them at an early age. Play allows children to create and explore a world they can master, conquering their fears while practicing adult roles, **developing new competencies** that lead to enhanced confidence and the resiliency they will need to face future challenges.

Child-directed play allows children to practice decision-making skills, move at their own pace, discover their own areas of interest, and ultimately engage fully in the passions they wish to pursue. When play is controlled by adults, children follow adult rules and lose some of the benefits child-directed play offers them, such as developing creativity, leadership, and group skills. Play builds active, healthy bodies. Play is a simple joy that is a cherished part of childhood. However, play can be challenged by child labor and exploitation practices, war and neighborhood violence, living in poverty, over scheduling, and pressures on children to achieve. (Ginsburg, 2007)

A wonderful resource to learn more about play is available on the [National Association for the Education of Young Children website](#). After reviewing the information on the website reflect on these questions:

How can we enhance the opportunities for balance in children's lives that will create the optimal development to prepare them to be academically, socially, and emotionally equipped for future growth? How can we make sure we play enough?

Conclusion

Genes make us human, but our humanity is a result of the complex interplay of biological and cultural factors. This week you read about the influences of family, society, and culture as they bear on the lives of children. As you discuss, try to answer: **How are interactions between children and adults shaped, modified and redefined by overlapping institutional and organizational forces such as the economy, family, education, politics, religion, and so on? What is the impact of experiences in childhood later in life?**

After reading this chapter and completing the activities you should be able to

- Describe and analyze the influences of family, society, and culture influence the lives of children as seen the discussion and assumptions inventory

Challenge

Reflection and Discussion

This week we explored the influences of family, society, and culture influence the lives of children. **Reflect** on your understanding of these ideas:

Socialization	Developmentalism	Gender
Play	Diversity	Friendship
Competence	Ethnicity	Ecological Systems Theory
Cultural Relativism	Familialization	

Now you are ready to type in Pages or in a Word document, a minimum of 3 paragraphs explaining your connections, extensions, and curiosities. Copy and paste your response in the Blackboard discussion or in class

Collaborative Research Project

So far during this course, you brainstormed a research question and should be using at least 2 disciplines to examine the question. Your work this week is to present your preliminary findings as a draft of the final project. Soon you will submit a video or some other oral report as well as written materials. You will likely use the same format as the Assumption Inventory. The report should

- Summarize your research question (**What**). Remember to relate the question to the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC)
- Present the research from different disciplines that help to answer or explain the question. (**So What**)
- Apply criteria listed in the grading rubrics to create a persuasive presentation
- Discuss possible solutions. (This is the start of the **NowWhat** of the project)
- Complete a peer feedback questionnaire.

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5: Impact of the Environment, Education, Economy, and Political Conditions on Childhood

Learning Objectives

During this chapter we will:

- Describe how childhood interactions and experiences are shaped, modified, and defined by institutional and organizational forces such as the economy, education, politics, and religion.
- Identify three to five major challenges facing children today.
- Explain strategies to determine, prioritize, and research issues of concern regarding children that reflect and amplify their voices.

Introduction

Last week we explored Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Theory and explored some of the influences closest to the child. This week we will explore societal and institutional influences on children. These are the influences from the Exosystem and Macrosystems. The disciplines of economics, education, political science, religion, social work, communications, and law offer insights on how these systems impact childhood.

Terms and Definitions

Important concepts to look for in this chapter:

- **Citizenship** is gained by meeting the legal requirements of a national, state, or local government. A nation grants certain rights and privileges to its citizens. In return, citizens are expected to obey their country's laws and defend it against its enemies. In some countries, citizenship can the right to vote, the right to hold government offices, and/or the right to collect unemployment. Living in a country does not mean that a person is necessarily a citizen of that country.
- **Cultural politics of Childhood:** The combination of the cultural context, social practices, and political processes through which childhood is constructed in different societies at different times.
- **Health:** A state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity (World Health Organization)
- **Innocence:** Being naïve or unexperienced and free from guilt.
- **Minority Group Status:** A subordinate group whose members have significantly less control or power over their lives than members of a dominant or majority group. Children are considered a minority group.
- **Poverty:** Poverty is often defined in absolute terms of **income poverty** when a family's income fails to meet a federally established threshold that differs across countries. Typically it is measured with respect to families and not the individual, and is adjusted for the number of persons in a family. **Absolute poverty** measures poverty in relation to the amount of money necessary to meet basic needs such as food, clothing, and shelter. **Relative poverty** defines poverty in relation to the economic status of other members of the society: people are poor if they fall below prevailing standards of living in a given societal context.
- **Schools and Schooling:** The process of educating children through a social institution of schools and the child's experience in that process.
- **Representation:** The linguistic or figurative process by which ideas are given significance and meaning in society. The topic of visual representations of childhood is approached from a number of different disciplines, including art, sociology, film, consumption, media, history, popular culture, and anthropology. **How is childhood represented in our culture?**
- **Resilience:** The process of adapting well in the face of adversity, trauma, tragedy, threats, or even significant sources of stress — such as family and relationship problems, serious health problems, or workplace and financial stressors. It means “bouncing back” from difficult experiences. ([American Psychological Association](https://www.apa.org/what-is-resilience))

Influences Shaping Childhood

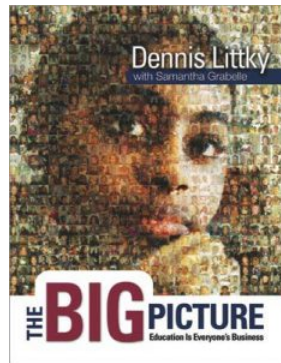
Economy and Law

Begin by reading the US Department of Labor website's information about [Family and Medical Leave Act](#) The Family and Medical Leave Act of 1993 helps to balance workplace demands with the medical needs of employees and their families. Did you

know that you are entitled to take up to 12 weeks of unpaid leave during a 12-month period for your own serious health condition, or to care for an immediate family member who has a serious health condition? You may also use the FMLA for an extended parental leave for the birth or adoption of a child, and for bonding with a new foster child. **How does current U.S. family leave policy actually deter new parents and caregivers from spending time with young children? What are the consequences for babies—and their mothers?**

Education and Social Work (Child Protection)

Read [Chapter 1 The Real Goals of Education](#) from *The Big Picture* (2004) by Dennis Littky and Samantha Grabelle.



Cover of the book *The Big Picture*

In the United States, historically, the purpose of education has evolved to meet the needs of society; from instructing youth in religious doctrine, to preparing them to live in a democracy, to assimilating immigrants into mainstream society, to preparing workers for the industrialized 20th century workplace. As educators prepare children and youth for a world that is rapidly changing, **what is the goal of education in the US?**

Is the goal to produce workers? When should children start working? The federal Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) spells out US child labor standards. The FLSA specifies the ages at which children or minors can perform certain jobs. Here are some highlights:

- Children under 18 years old can't do certain jobs that are hazardous, such as working with explosives and coal mining
- Children who are at least 16 may work on farms and perform hazardous jobs, such as drive machinery
- Minors who're at 14 years old may work on farms, but it must be during non-school hours. And, children who're at least 12 may do farm work if the work it's done: (1) Outside of school hours; (2) with his parent's permission, and; (3) the parent also works on the farm
- Children under 12 years old may work on a farm outside of school hours if his parent(s) or guardians own or operate the farm
- During the summer or when school is out of session, children under 16 years old may work up to 40 hours per week. During the school year, they can't work more than three hours per day on a school day and no more than 18 hours a week in total

Public Policy and Law

Begin by reading the Massachusetts General Law regarding best interest of children in custody cases. Here are some legal decisions from courts in Massachusetts. As you read the summary of the cases, **was the decision of the court or judge in the best interest of the child? Why or why not?**

CASE 1: [Mason v. Coleman](#) , 447 Mass. 177 (2006) discusses the rights and responsibilities of parents with shared legal and physical custody of their children. A mother who shared joint physical and legal custody of her children with their father sought to remove the children from the Commonwealth of MA and the father refused to consent to the removal, a probate judge appropriately considered the best interests of the children and did not abuse her discretion in concluding that removal of the children would not serve their best interests. The decision did not violate the mother's right to freedom of movement pursuant to the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution In order for a parent who shares joint physical custody to move out of state, she or he must meet a higher standard than a parent who has sole physical custody. *"The importance to the children of one parent's advantage in relocating outside the Commonwealth is greatly reduced."* Applying the "best interests of the child" test, the court determined that the mother would not be permitted to move out of state.

CASE 2: [Yannas v. Frondistou-Yannas](#) , 395 Mass. 704 (1985) In detail, outlines how the best interests of the child are to be determined in deciding a case in which one parent who has sole physical custody wants to move out of state. In a divorce

proceeding in which custody of the parties' two minor children was in issue, the evidence warranted the judge's conclusion that awarding physical custody to the wife was in the best interests of each child. A judge in a divorce proceeding, having awarded physical custody to the mother allowed her to move of the children from Massachusetts to Greece because it would be in the best interests of the children. The move to Greece would benefit the mother, financially, emotionally, and socially; that the children would benefit from that advantage and from the strengthening of family and cultural ties in Greece; that excellent schooling would be available to them; and that reasonable alternative arrangements for visitation with their father would be arranged. **What is in the best interest of children?**

Representations

The topic of visual representations of childhood is approached from a number of different disciplines, including art, sociology, film, consumption, media, history, popular culture, and anthropology. What adjectives do you use to describe childhood? Take a moment and write down 3-5 words. What adjectives do you use to describe adulthood? Write down 3-5 words.

Did you use any of the following words: sinful, violent, carefree or happy. How did your lists compare? Why do you suppose you likely notice differences? **What does this tell you about the social construction of childhood?**

Read [The melodrama of being a child](#) by Karen Wells. Wells (2013) discusses how international non-governmental organisations (INGOs) address the causes of poverty and seek to enrich the lives of children. She explores the methods that INGOs use to increase awareness of the impacts of poverty on children and to raise funds for assisting those children. The representations of poverty disseminated by INGOs films place that the figure of the child centrally in their campaigns. Wells examines the issues of child-saving to child-rights using mise-en-scène to explore the theatrical presentation of suffering. **Mise-en-scène** means, literally, "put in the scene" consists of all the elements placed in front of the camera to be photographed: settings, props, lighting, costumes, makeup, and figure behavior (meaning actors, their gestures, and their facial expressions). Analyze the photos below, looking at:

- Composition—Is the shot a close-up, far away, or somewhere in the middle? Is it straight on, overhead, or looking up at the action?
- Scene—Where did the photo take place?
- Props—What are the characters holding, interacting with, moving around the setting? What's in the background?
- Actors—Who plays which part? Do they "fit" the role or are they miscast?
- Costumes—What are the characters wearing? How do their clothes affect the way we understand them and their world?
- Lighting—Is the shot bright (high key), dark (low-key), somewhere in the middle? Are there shadows? What direction does the light come from?

How does the photo represent child saving (politics of pity) and child rights (politics of justice)? Should we appeal to pity or justice when we work to change the settings for childhood? Why or why not? What messages do the images you are finding as you research your topic and question, say about children?

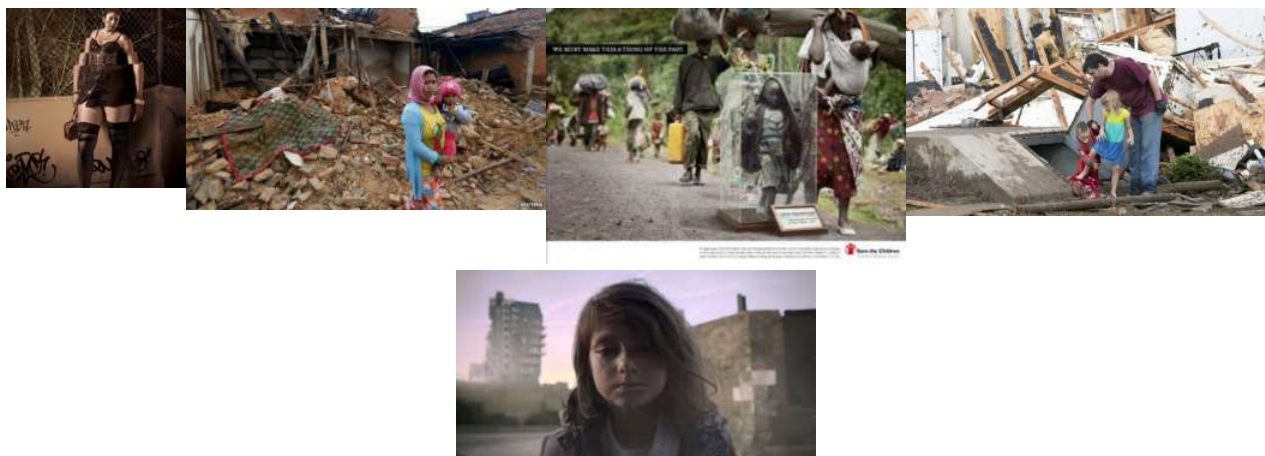


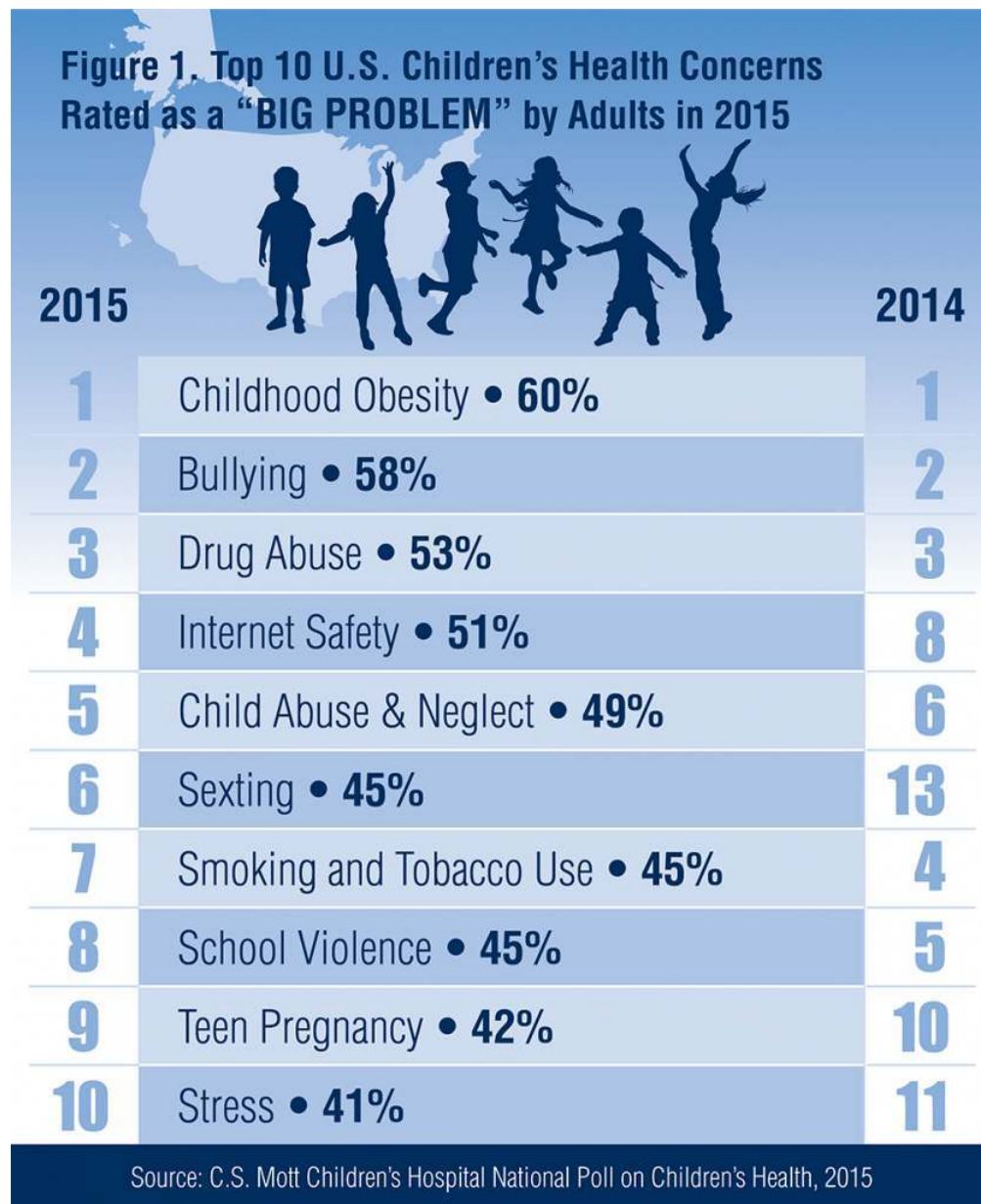
Figure 5.1: Paste Caption Here

Major Challenges Facing Children Today

The greatest change in childhood over time is the changing concept of childhood. There is a constant transformation of society's attitudes toward children. Some families shelter their children from life's uncertainties while some expose children early to adult experience in order to survive in an uncontrollable world. I think that more people expose children early. What do you think? The Age of Protection is ending and an Age of Preparation is setting in. Children are integrated at a young age into the adult world, in every way their lives have become more difficult, more confusing – in short, more like adult lives. **How do children move from innocence to competence? How do we protect children yet prepare them for life? What is in their best interest?**

Health

Here is a list of the Top 10 Health Concerns. Does the list reflect Protection or Preparation? **What are biggest health concerns in your community?** Related to our discussion last week on poverty, did you know that evidence shows that in general the lower an individual's socioeconomic position the worse their health (World Health Organization).



Top 10 Health Challenges 2015

Public Policies and Politics

Watch [The Raising of America](#) video clips (see 11 minute trailer from the series on Blackboard) and explore the website to learn more about the five-part documentary series that explores the question: Why are so many children in America faring so poorly? What are the consequences for the nation's future? How might we, as a nation, do better? The series investigates these questions through different disciplines: What does science tell us about the enduring importance of early life experiences on the brain and body? What it is like to be a parent today? And what policies and structures help or hinder the raising of healthy, happy and compassionate children?

Did you know that wages for average Americans have stagnated over the last forty years. At the same time, the cost of essentials (like housing and education) has substantially increased while corporate profits have skyrocketed. **How does this pattern affect childhood?**

Some facts to consider from **Raising of America**

- Most women work and 40% of new mothers return to work by the time their babies are three months old. Former Investment banker and economist Robert Dugger says, “Our policies actually actively discourage parents from being able to take care of their children when they’re very young. They may instinctively want to do it, but we don’t make it easy for them.”
- Ashley a welfare recipient says, “Everybody thinks that you get state assistance, well you’re just lazy and you don’t want to work. That’s not the case for the majority and that’s sure not the case for me.” Given its inaccuracy, why do you think the stereotyping of people in need of public assistance as “lazy” persists? What kind of public assistance do wealthy people receive?
- Why do so many people blame parents for making “wrong” or “irresponsible” decisions rather than address how the dice are loaded against them? How does this impact the policies and programs enacted to support low-income families with children?
- **If tomorrow you could make one change to employment policies that would make life better for your children (or the children in your care or community), what would you change and why?**

Schools and Schooling & Working Children

Did you know that a 7-year-old living in the United States may have picked the blueberries in your refrigerator? Hundreds of thousands of child farmworkers are working in the U.S. at younger ages, for longer hours, and facing greater risks than any other working youth, according to a [new report by the Human Rights Watch](#). The organization is one of 53 that support a bill pending in Congress called The Children’s Act for Responsible Employment (CARE) Act. The bill would amend the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) of 1938 **and offer child farmworkers the same legal protections as youth in every other industry**. “The United States spends over \$25 million a year — more than all other countries combined — to eliminate child labor abroad, yet is tolerating exploitative child labor in its own backyard,” said Zama Coursen-Neff, author of the report. The report found children as young as 12 legally working more than 10 hours a day. **Take a look at the 2015 report: [Teens of the Tobacco Fields Child Labor in United States Tobacco Farming](#)** Physically, developmentally, and socially, children are different from adults, and these differences leave them uniquely vulnerable to the harmful effects of working in tobacco farming. US laws and regulations have no special provisions to restrict children’s work in tobacco, despite the documented dangers of the work. **Why do children work? How does it impact their education?**

Strategies to reduce or alleviate challenges

[Harvard Center on the Developing Child](#) drives science-based innovation that achieve breakthrough outcomes for children facing adversity. They have wonderful multimedia resources to learn more. I recommend playing [Tipping the Scales: The Resilience Game](#) and 3-minute video “[Brain Hero](#)” depicting how actions by a range of people in the family and community impact child development. Safe, stable and nurturing relationships and environments help build strong foundations. They are the most powerful protective forces in a young child’s life.

What is resilience and why is it important to understand the concept? How can you support resilience in children?

Summary

Is there a relationship between social policy and the social construction of childhood? The Exosystem and Macrosystem provide the setting for childhood. Many disciplines contribute to our understanding of these influences in a variety of context. **What is the moral of the story for Week 4?**

After completing the reading and weekly activities you should be able to

- Describe how childhood interactions and experiences are shaped, modified, and defined by institutional and organizational forces such as the economy, education, politics, and religion as seen in your discussion and final project draft.
- Identify three to five major challenges facing children today as seen in your discussion and final project draft.
- Explain strategies to determine, prioritize, and research issues of concern regarding children that reflect and amplify their voices as seen in your discussion and final project draft.

Past Students Questions

How come some children are not affected by their childhood as much as others? Does it all just depend on the child?

Should a parent be obligated to spend a certain amount of hours a day with their child to show them they love and care for them even if the parent's life is busy?

Challenges

Reflection and Discussion

As you prepare for the discussion, reflect on the questions:

How do you interpret the ways in which environmental, educational, economic and political conditions affect children?

How does current U.S. family leave policy actually deter new parents and caregivers from spending time with young children? What are the consequences for babies—and their mothers ?

If tomorrow you could make one change to employment policies that would make life better for your children (or the children in your care or community), what would you change and why?

What is the goal of education in the US? Why do children work? How does it impact their education?

How do representations influence the social construction of childhood? How do children move from innocence to competence? How do we protect children yet prepare them for life? What is in their best interest?

Group Research Continued

Looking ahead to next week remember that you will present your Collaborative Research Project early in the week. The assignment includes an 8 to 10 minute video and supporting written materials such as presentation slides or documents including your sources. The video puts everything together the question (What), research (So What), and conclude with Now What where you discuss possible solutions. You will add a group reflection to address: how the insights from different disciplines contributed to your understanding of the issue as well as your new ideas about children and childhood. As you work remember to:

- Clearly state the research question and logically and convincingly describe the significance of the question to Childhood Studies
- Logically and persuasively answer the research question.
- Explain limitations of research
- Clearly describe how you used the disciplinary perspectives to answer the question
- Make 3 recommendations for further research
- Explain how the insights from different disciplines contributed to the understanding of the issue as well as your new ideas about children and childhood
- Create visuals that enhance and illustrate the verbal message.
- Discuss 5 to 7 reliable and scholarly sources to support your claims. Making sure that each discipline has 2 or more sources.

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6: Suggested Reading

James, A., & James, A. (2012). (2nd Ed) *Key Concepts in Childhood Studies*. London available in [Google Books](#).

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